

and the demons were ‘within their rights’, under Satan, who was still the god of this world. But the demons were obviously worried! (They knew very well who Jesus was, and what He could do.) I would say that this is one of the ‘greater things’ (John 14:12) that we may now do—rather, that we should do. As for forbidding any further demonic activity, we have the Lord’s example (Mark 9:25), and we are to do what He did (John 14:12).

Take their thoughts captive to the obedience of Christ:

This procedure is based on 2 Corinthians 10:5. In the context, the thoughts are of people who are serving Satan (even if unwittingly). (Of course we should always be checking to be sure that we ourselves are operating within ‘the mind of Christ’, 1 Corinthians 2:15-16.) Now this procedure moves away from simply neutralizing the enemy’s interference, since it introduces a positive ‘interference’, but it is relevant to the issue being discussed here, since it is protection against falling back into the former error. Again we must be specific.

Some further texts that may apply:

Luke 4:18-21, Psalm 149:5-9, John 14:12.

In Luke 4:18-21 Jesus includes “to set at liberty those who are oppressed” (Isaiah 58:6) as one of the things He was sent to do. Turning to Isaiah 58:6, we find Jehovah stating what kind of ‘fast’ He would like to see: “To loose the fetters of wickedness [a], to undo the yoke-ropes [b]; to let oppressed ones go free [a], and that you (pl.) break every yoke [b].” As is typical of Hebrew grammar, the two halves are parallel. “To loose the fetters of wickedness” and “to let oppressed ones go free” are parallel. Who placed the “fetters” and who is doing the oppressing? Well, although people can certainly forge their own bonds through their own wicked lifestyle, I take it that the point here is that wicked beings have placed the fetters on others. “To undo yoke-ropes” and “that ye break every yoke” go together. First we should untie the ropes that bind the yoke to the neck, then we should break the yokes themselves. I gain the clear impression that this text is talking about the activity of Satan’s servants, men and angels. Using culture, worldview, legal devices, threats, blackmail, lies, deception and just plain demonizing and witchcraft, they bind individuals, families, ethnic groups, etc., with a variety of fetters and instruments of oppression.

So what does this have to do with our subject? Well, fasting was an important and required component in their worship of God. So this kind of ‘fasting’ is something that Jehovah overtly wants to see; it is specifically His will. So when we see any work of Satan in someone’s life, it is God’s